SEVEN

Job interviews are generally tailored to judge how well the interviewee can convince the interviewer that he or she is fit for the job. It is even more challenging when the interviewer is hell-bent on finding a good reason to deem the candidate unfit. How do you convince them in such a situation? The answer is—with honesty. That is what is required in the personal interviews of the SSB exam, according to Papaji. He would tell me that if I missed even one of the prerequisite qualities, the armed forces would not even consider my candidature; it would not put the lives of its men and women at risk just because someone like me would lose a job opportunity. So making sugar-coated statements wasn't going to help at all. If one is not chosen, it's better to accept the inevitable rather than feel disheartened, prepare well and execute better in the next SSB exam. On the morning of the fifth day, just before the personal interviews were to commence, I promised myself I would not crib or cry if I failed—I would accept the results calmly and go back like a true fighter.

'I wonder if we'll get tickets to go back home tonight, in case we don't get recommended?' Deepa asked. We were all sitting in rows outside the conference hall, waiting for the interviews to begin. There were two bulbs fitted to sockets above the hall's door, one red and one green. The red one was glowing, indicating an interview was in progress inside.

'You think you won't make it?' I asked Deepa in a hushed tone.